

COMPLETE UNIT

KS3: Early Modern World & Global Encounters (1450–1750)



COURSE TEXTBOOK

*Enquiry: How 'global' was Britain's transformation between
1450 and 1750?*

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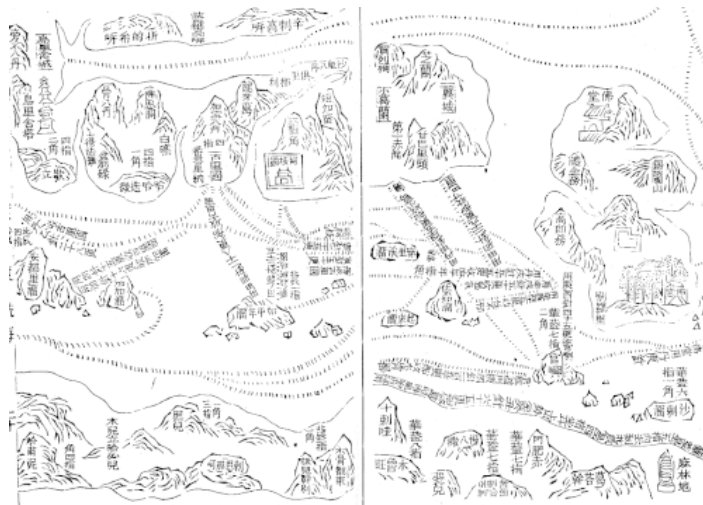
Lesson 9: How 'modern' was Britain by 1750? (Synthesis & Assessment)

L1: Who held global power in 1450?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

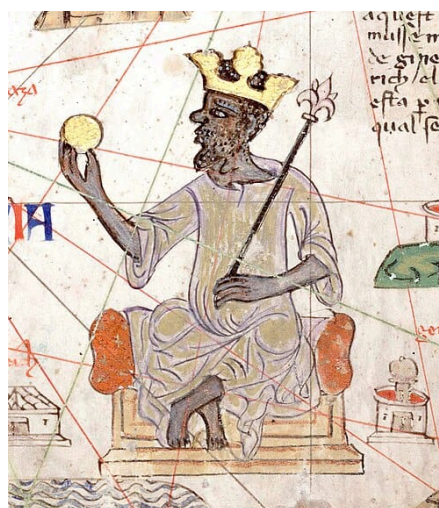
- ☐ Understand the scale, naval technology, and commercial output of Ming Dynasty China under the Yongle Emperor and Admiral Zheng He.
- ☐ Analyze the geopolitical consequences of the Ottoman capture of Constantinople in 1453.
- ☐ Evaluate the wealth of West African empires using the Catalan Atlas and primary accounts of Mansa Musa.

Source A : Stone Inscription of Admiral Zheng He at Changle, Fujian (1431)



Carved stone pillar commemorating the voyages of Admiral Zheng He's imperial treasure fleet across the Indian Ocean to Arabia and Africa.

Source B : The Catalan Atlas Depiction of Mansa Musa of Mali (1375)



Illuminated maritime map by Majorcan Jewish cartographer Cresques Abraham, depicting the Emperor of Mali seated upon a golden throne holding a massive gold nugget.

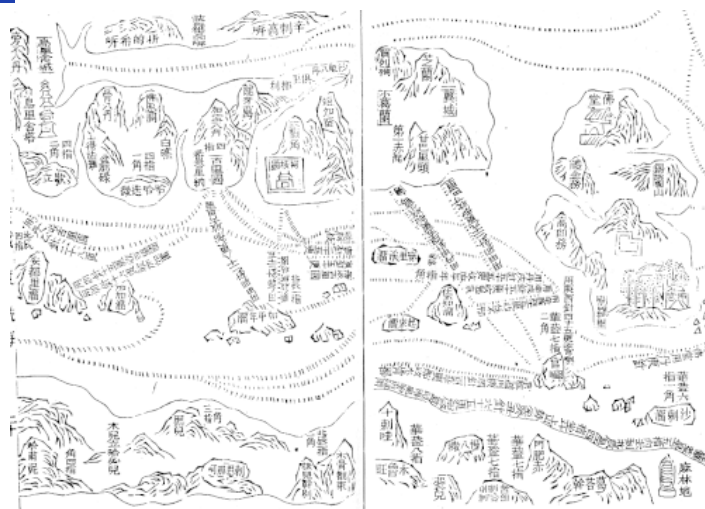
[1.1] In popular imagination, the modern world is often imagined as a European invention. Yet if an alien observer had orbited the earth in the year 1450, Western Europe would have appeared as little more than an impoverished, war-torn, and disease-ravaged peripheral backwater. Europe was still reeling from the demographic shock of the Black Death, which had annihilated between a third and a half of its population just a century earlier. England and France were trapped in the final bloody gasps of the Hundred Years' War; rival baronies fought in the mud, literacy was restricted to a tiny Latin-speaking clerical elite, and London was a smelly, unpaved commercial town of barely 50,000 souls.

[1.2] By sharp contrast, the true centers of global wealth, industrial manufacturing, and demographic power lay thousands of miles to the east and south. In 1450, the Mediterranean was not a European lake, but the western terminal of vast afro- Eurasian trade arteries connecting the spices of the Moluccas, the silks of China, and the goldfields of West Africa. European monarchs possessed neither the naval technology to cross oceans nor the manufactured goods that Asian and African empires desired; Europe had little to offer the world except silver bullion and raw wool.

[2.1] The undisputed economic and technological superpower of the fifteenth century was **Ming Dynasty China**. Ruling over 100 million citizens, China was an urban, bureaucratic, and industrial giant. Between 1405 and 1433, Emperor Yongle dispatched seven monumental naval expeditions commanded by **Admiral Zheng He**. Zheng He's fleets were staggering: over 300 ships carrying 28,000 men, featuring nine-masted "Treasure Ships" (*baochuan*) up to 400 feet long with watertight bulkheads and magnetic compasses. These fleets sailed effortlessly across the Indian Ocean to India, the Persian Gulf, and the East African coast, distributing silks and blue-and-white porcelain to awe foreign rulers into paying tribute.

[2.2] Meanwhile, on Europe's immediate eastern doorstep, a formidable new Islamic superpower was rising: the **Ottoman Empire**. In May 1453, twenty-one-year-old Sultan **Mehmed II** deployed gigantic bronze super-cannons and 80,000 soldiers to besiege Constantinople, the ancient capital of the Byzantine Empire. The city fell on 29 May 1453, ending over 1,100 years of Roman imperial continuity. Mehmed transformed the city into Istanbul, the glittering seat of Ottoman power. Crucially for Europe, the Ottomans now controlled the Bosphorus and Mediterranean trade terminals, imposing hefty customs tariffs and blocking European merchants from accessing the Silk Roads.

Source A : Stone Inscription of Admiral Zheng He at Changle, Fujian (1431)



Carved stone pillar commemorating the voyages of Admiral Zheng He's imperial treasure fleet across the Indian Ocean to Arabia and Africa.

[3.1] Forensic examination of primary artifacts demonstrates how self-assured the great non-European empires were. In his 1431 Fujian stone inscription (Source A), Zheng He recorded that China had *"traversed more than one hundred thousand li of immense waters"* to treat distant barbarians with kindness and display *"the transforming power of imperial virtue."* China had no desire to conquer foreign

lands or establish overseas settler colonies because Chinese emperors believed their Middle Kingdom already possessed everything under heaven. Consequently, when Confucian court officials judged the voyages too expensive, the fleet was ordered to rot at anchor and foreign voyages were outlawed in 1433.

[3.2] Similarly, in West Africa, the Mali and Songhai empires commanded immense commercial wealth. The legendary 1324 pilgrimage to Mecca by Emperor **Mansa Musa** had introduced so much pure gold into Cairo's economy that the metal's value was depressed for twelve years! European cartographers in Majorca drew the famous Catalan Atlas of 1375 (Source B) showing Mansa Musa crowned in gold, brandishing an enormous gold nugget like an apple. African kingdoms like the Kingdom of Benin cast intricate brass and bronze sculptures displaying sophisticated metallurgical mastery that rivaled anything produced in Renaissance Italy.

[4.1] Modern global historians, such as Professor Peter Frankopan in *The Silk Roads* (2015), have radically revised traditional Eurocentric narratives. Frankopan demonstrates that for thousands of years, the beating heart of world history was the Eurasian crossroads—Persia, Central Asia, and China—not Western Europe. The European "Age of Discovery" was not the inevitable triumph of European cultural genius; rather, it was born out of profound weakness and geographic desperation. Cut off from Asian trade by the Ottoman superpower, European kingdoms had to gamble on the open, terrifying Atlantic Ocean or remain impoverished forever.

[4.2] The year 1450 marks the calm before a global storm. Within fifty years, small, desperate Portuguese and Spanish ships would round the Cape of Good Hope and stumble across the Americas, triggering a violent reordering of the planet. Yet in 1450, the rulers of Beijing, Istanbul, and Timbuktu would have laughed out loud at the suggestion that a tiny island called England would one day build the largest global empire in human history.

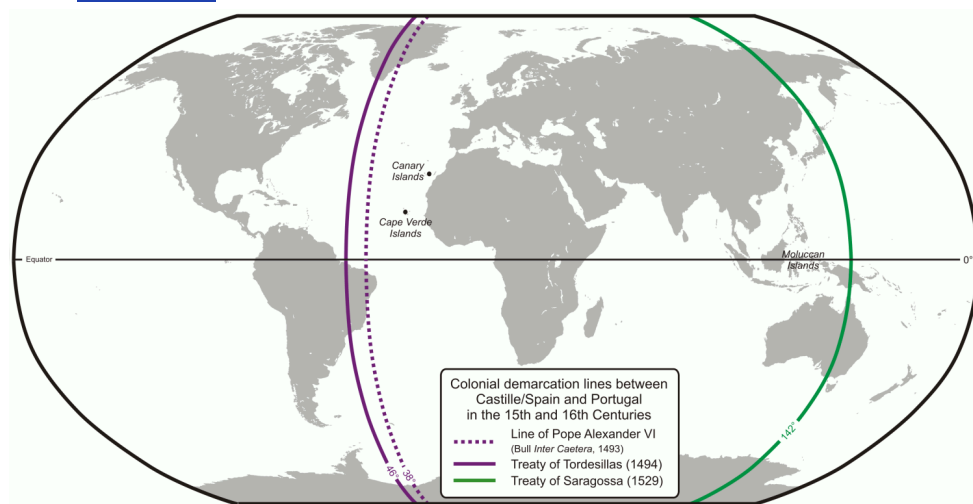
Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L2: How did religious conflict trigger global exploration (1517–1588)?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the catalyst of the Protestant Reformation in 1517 and its global imperial repercussions.
- ☐ Analyze the Treaty of Tordesillas (1494) and English defiance via privateering and piracy.
- ☐ Evaluate the symbolism of the Armada Portrait and the defeat of the Spanish Armada in 1588.

Source A : Map of the Treaty of Tordesillas Meridian Line (1494)



Papal meridian line drawn by Pope Alexander VI in 1493 and finalized at Tordesillas in 1494, dividing the entire non-European globe between Spain and Portugal.

Source B : The Armada Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I (1588)



Masterpiece attributed to George Gower commemorating the English defeat of the Spanish Armada, depicting Elizabeth with her hand resting upon the globe.

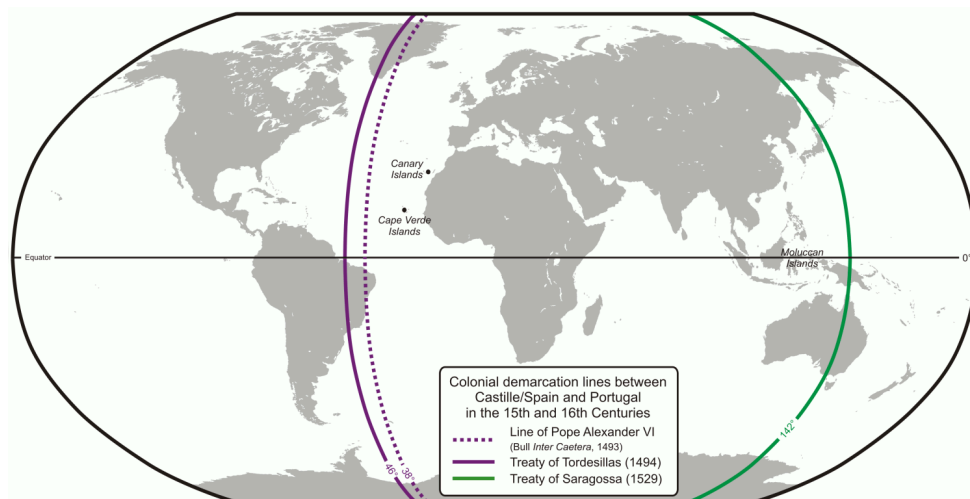
[1.1] In October 1517, an obscure German monk named **Martin Luther** nailed ninety-five theses to the church door in Wittenberg, attacking the corruption of the Catholic papacy. Luther argued that salvation was achieved through personal faith alone, not by purchasing papal indulgences or submitting to Roman hierarchy. Luther's protest ignited the **Protestant Reformation**, tearing Europe into two violently hostile religious camps: Catholic kingdoms loyal to the Pope (led by the mighty Habsburg superpower of Spain), and Protestant states (eventually including England, Scotland, the Netherlands, and northern Germany) who viewed the Pope as the Antichrist.

[1.2] Meanwhile, Spain and Portugal had already struck maritime gold. In 1494, Pope Alexander VI mediated the **Treaty of Tordesillas** (Source A), audaciously drawing an imaginary meridian line down the Atlantic Ocean: all non-Christian lands discovered to the west belonged exclusively to Spain, while everything to the east belonged to Portugal. Spanish conquistadors like Cortés and Pizarro annihilated the Aztec and Inca empires, establishing a colossal silver-mining empire in Mexico and Peru. To Spanish King Philip II, this tidal wave of silver was not merely cash: it was divine funding provided by God to build invincible armies and crush Protestant heretics worldwide.

[2.1] In England, King Henry VIII broke with Rome in 1534 to secure a divorce, declaring himself Supreme Head of the Church of England. By the time his daughter **Elizabeth I** ascended the throne in 1558, England was a vulnerable Protestant island surrounded by powerful Catholic enemies. Excommunicated by Pope Pius V in 1570—who commanded English Catholics to depose their "heretic queen"—Elizabeth could not afford a full-scale war against Spain's legendary infantry, the *tercios*. Instead, she turned to state-sponsored maritime piracy.

[2.2] Elizabeth secretly licensed audacious Devon sea captains—the infamous "**Sea Dogs**", including **Sir Francis Drake** and **Sir John Hawkins**. Armed with royal letters of marque, Drake ambushed Spanish treasure galleons in the Caribbean, looted silver mule-trains in Panama, and between 1577 and 1580 became the first Englishman to circumnavigate the globe in the *Golden Hind*. When Drake returned to Plymouth laden with tons of looted Spanish silver—yielding an astonishing 4,700 percent return on investment—Philip II furiously demanded his head. Instead, Elizabeth brazenly boarded Drake's ship in London and knighted him on his own quarterdeck, openly mocking the Spanish superpower!

Source A : Map of the Treaty of Tordesillas Meridian Line (1494)



Papal meridian line drawn by Pope Alexander VI in 1493 and finalized at Tordesillas in 1494, dividing the entire non-European globe between Spain and Portugal.

[3.1] Enraged by English piracy, Elizabeth's military support for Dutch Protestant rebels, and the execution of Catholic Mary Queen of Scots in 1587, Philip II launched his "Enterprise of England" in July 1588: the **Spanish Armada**. A colossal fleet of 130 warships carrying 30,000 soldiers sailed up the English Channel in an unbreakable crescent formation, intending to ferry an invasion army across from Flanders and restore Catholicism to England at sword-point. But off Calais on 7 August, English commanders launched

eight blazing hellburner fireships into the anchored Armada, throwing the Spanish galleons into midnight panic and scattering their formations.

[3.2] The next day at the Battle of Gravelines, faster English race-built galleons pounded the disorganized Spanish ships at long range. Battered and blown northward by ferocious North Sea gales, the Armada was forced to attempt a catastrophic voyage home around the rocky coasts of Scotland and Ireland, where dozens of ships were smashed to kindling on the Atlantic rocks. The triumphant English struck a commemorative medal reading: *"God blew, and they were scattered."* In the famous **Armada Portrait** (Source B), Elizabeth is immortalized surrounded by royal pearls, her hand resting upon the global Americas while the shattered Spanish fleet flounders in tempestuous seas behind her.

[4.1] Historians debate whether the Elizabethan naval struggle was primarily motivated by genuine religious zeal or by naked financial greed. Victorian historians painted Elizabeth's Sea Dogs as Protestant freedom fighters standing bravely against Spanish Catholic tyranny. However, modern economic historians point out that Drake and Hawkins were primarily commercial opportunists and slave traders whose religious rhetoric conveniently justified ruthless robbery on the high seas.

[4.2] Nevertheless, the psychological impact of 1588 was profound. The defeat of the Armada shattered the aura of Spanish naval invincibility and proved to English merchants that the Atlantic was open. For the first time, English investors began to dream of establishing permanent overseas colonies, laying the ideological and commercial foundations for what would become the British Empire.

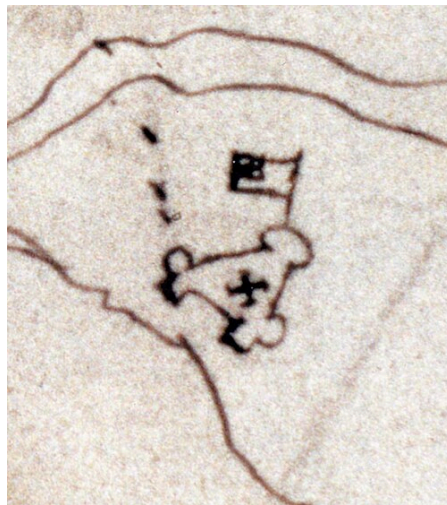
Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L3: Trade or takeover: How did early encounters turn into empire?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the revolutionary financial structure of the joint-stock company.
- ☐ Analyze the survival mechanisms of Jamestown (1607) and the introduction of cash-crop tobacco.
- ☐ Contrast the American experience with Sir Thomas Roe's embassy to Mughal Emperor Jahangir.

Source A : Contemporary Plan of the Jamestown Triangular Fort (1607)



Architectural plan of the fortified settlement built by the Virginia Company along the James River, showing artillery bastions at each triangle corner.

Source B : Sir Thomas Roe at the Imperial Court of Mughal Emperor Jahangir (1615)



Mughal miniature painting depicting King James I's ambassador Sir Thomas Roe presenting credentials and gifts to Emperor Jahangir in Agra.

[1.1] At the turn of the seventeenth century, English overseas expansion underwent an institutional revolution. Monarchs like Elizabeth I and James I were chronically broke; they could never finance state-run fleets like the Spanish Crown. Instead, London merchants pioneered a radical capitalist financial vehicle: the **joint-stock company**. Rather than a single merchant risking his entire fortune on a perilous three-year oceanic voyage, hundreds of investors bought transferable company shares. If a ship sank or was seized by pirates, an investor lost only what they had invested; if the ship returned laden with cloves, nutmeg, or silk, the profits were divided proportionally. This spread of financial risk unlocked immense pools of private capital.

[1.2] On New Year's Eve 1600, Elizabeth I signed a royal charter creating "*The Governor and Company of Merchants of London trading into the East Indies*"—the **East India Company (EIC)**. Granted a royal monopoly on all English trade east of the Cape of Good Hope, the EIC sailed into the Indian Ocean not with royal armies, but with ledgers, silver coins, and cargo manifests. Six years later in 1606, King James I chartered the **Virginia Company of London** to establish private profitable colonies along the North American Atlantic coast.

[2.1] England's initial colonial venture was an unmitigated disaster. In May 1607, three small Virginia Company ships landed 104 wealthy gentlemen, jewelers, and servants in Virginia, founding **Jamestown**. Expecting to discover gold and rubies like Spanish conquistadors, the pampered gentlemen refused to plant crops or dig wells. By winter, over half had perished from dysentery and starvation. During the horrific "Starving Time" of 1609–1610, desperate settlers ate roots, rats, their own leather boots, and in one gruesome instance, a settler reportedly cannibalized his deceased wife! The colony was saved from total annihilation only when John Rolfe crossbred a sweet Caribbean tobacco strain, sparking an addictive European cash-crop craze that turned Virginia into an agrarian boomtown hungry for indigenous land.

[2.2] Meanwhile on the other side of the planet, the East India Company encountered a civilization that made London look like a village: the **Mughal Empire** in India. Ruling over 150 million subjects—a fifth of humanity—the Mughal Empire commanded an economy generating 25 percent of the world's industrial output, famous for exquisite calico cottons, raw silk, and indigo. When English ships arrived off Gujarat, local governors viewed the newcomers as ragged coastal peddlers. To secure permanent trading footholds, King James I dispatched an aristocratic ambassador, **Sir Thomas Roe**, in 1615 to the glittering imperial court at Agra.

Source A : Contemporary Plan of the Jamestown Triangular Fort (1607)



Architectural plan of the fortified settlement built by the Virginia Company along the James River, showing artillery bastions at each triangle corner.

[3.1] Primary documents expose the immense vulnerability of early English expansion. The original architectural blueprint of Jamestown (Source A) shows a rigid triangular fort bristling with artillery bastions at each corner. This was not a monument to imperial conquest, but a desperate panic shelter: surrounded by the powerful Powhatan Confederacy and terrified of Catholic Spanish galleons, English settlers lived locked behind wooden palisades, dependent on trading copper kettles and glass beads to Chief Powhatan for baskets of life-saving corn.

[3.2] An even sharper contrast is documented in Sir Thomas Roe's journals from the court of Mughal Emperor **Jahangir** (Source B). Roe was stunned by the unimaginable luxury of the Mughal court: Jahangir sat upon golden thrones encrusted with diamonds and emeralds, surrounded by thousands of courtiers. Roe's English gifts—heavy woollen cloth and a clockwork coach—were regarded by the Emperor with mild amusement as primitive curiosities. Jahangir eventually granted the Company an imperial *farman* (decree) allowing them to construct a "factory" (a fortified trading warehouse) at Surat, not out of fear, but because the Mughals welcomed foreign silver bullion into their treasury.

[4.1] In 1883, imperial historian Sir John Seeley coined a famous historical aphorism: *"We seem, as it were, to have conquered and peopled half the world in a fit of absence of mind."* Seeley argued that the British Empire was never a pre-meditated government conspiracy; it emerged organically from the dispersed, private initiatives of adventurous merchants and desperate settlers who merely wanted to buy spices and grow tobacco.

[4.2] Modern post-colonial historians, such as Professor Shashi Tharoor, present a far more critical interpretation. They demonstrate that while expansion began as trade, the logic of capitalist monopolies made territorial conquest inevitable. To protect their commercial profits, corporate trading posts like the East India Company built private mercenary armies, constructed stone forts, and bribed or intimidated local rulers. Over the next 150 years, the company's accounting clerks would gradually transform themselves into imperial rulers, setting the stage for the total colonial conquest of the Indian subcontinent.

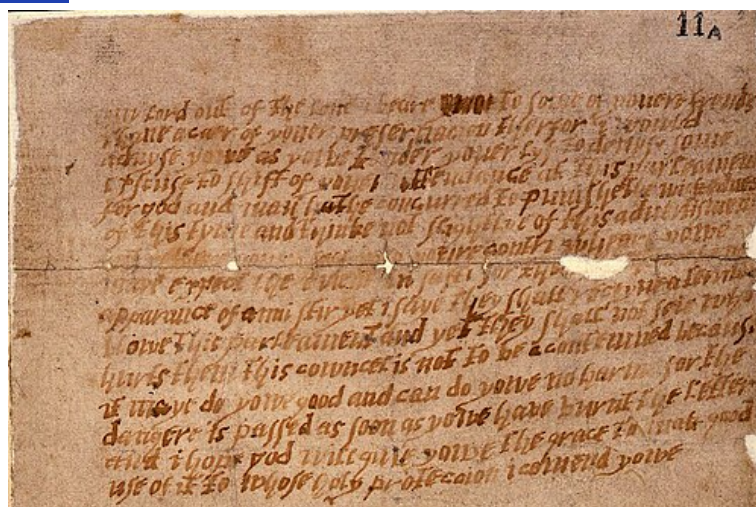
Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L4: James I and the Gunpowder Plot: Why was religious division so volatile?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

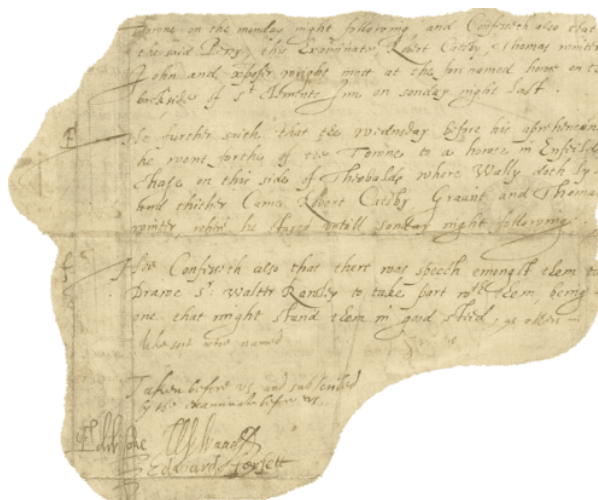
- ☐ Understand the catalyst of Catholic disappointment under James I and the doctrine of the Divine Right of Kings.
- ☐ Examine the forensic evidence of the conspiracy: the Monteagle Letter and Guy Fawkes' interrogation.
- ☐ Evaluate the political consequences of the Plot for British religious identity and state power.

Source A : The Anonymous Monteagle Warning Letter (October 1605)



Anonymous letter delivered to Catholic peer Lord Monteagle on 26 October 1605, warning him to avoid Parliament because "they shall receive a terrible blow."

Source B : Guy Fawkes' Signatures Before and After Torture (November 1605)



Official interrogation documents showing Guy Fawkes' steady initial signature using his alias "John Johnson", compared with his faint, trembling signature after eight days on the rack.

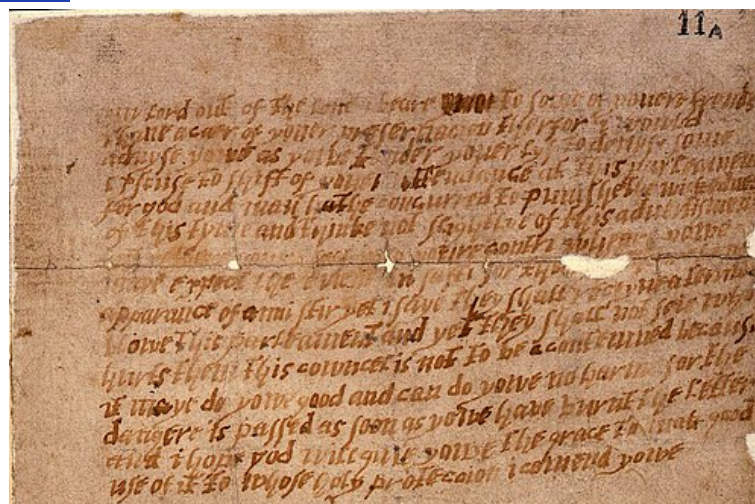
[1.1] In March 1603, Queen Elizabeth I died without leaving an heir, ending the Tudor dynasty. The English crown passed peacefully to her cousin, King **James VI of Scotland**, who became King **James I of England**, uniting the two crowns in personal union. English Roman Catholics—who had suffered decades of persecution, secret masses in priest holes, and crippling recusancy fines under Elizabeth—greeted James's arrival with cautious optimism. After all, James's own mother, Mary Queen of Scots, had been a devout Catholic martyr beheaded by Elizabeth.

[1.2] However, Catholic hopes were swiftly and brutally dashed. James was an intellectual who believed passionately in the **Divine Right of Kings**—the theological doctrine that monarchs were appointed directly by God Almighty and answered to no earthly authority, least of all the Pope. Terrified that tolerating Catholics would provoke powerful Puritan MPs in Parliament, James cracked down hard in 1604: he ordered all Catholic priests expelled from England and strictly enforced the ruinous twenty-pound monthly fine on families who refused to attend Protestant church services.

[2.1] Driven to fury by this betrayal, a charismatic, sword-wielding Catholic gentleman named **Robert Catesby** organized an audacious terrorist plot. Catesby gathered a tight-knit circle of twelve conspirators, including Thomas Wintour, Thomas Percy, and an experienced explosives mercenary named **Guy (Guido) Fawkes**, who had spent a decade fighting for the Catholic Spanish army in Flanders. Their objective was apocalyptic: to assassinate King James, his Protestant heirs, and the entire political ruling class in a single catastrophic explosion at the State Opening of Parliament, kidnap the King's nine-year-old daughter Princess Elizabeth, and install her as a puppet Catholic queen.

[2.2] In May 1604, Percy rented a ground-floor coal vault directly beneath the House of Lords. Over several months, Fawkes—posing as Percy's servant under the false identity "John Johnson"—smuggled **thirty-six barrels of gunpowder** across the Thames by night, containing over 2,500 kilograms of high explosive. Fawkes concealed the lethal barrels beneath heavy piles of firewood and iron bars. The blast would have demolished Westminster Palace, pulverized everyone inside into dust, and shattered windows across London miles away.

Source A : The Anonymous Monteagle Warning Letter (October 1605)



Anonymous letter delivered to Catholic peer Lord Monteagle on 26 October 1605, warning him to avoid Parliament because "they shall receive a terrible blow."

[3.1] The conspiracy unraveled through a single fatal letter. Several conspirators worried that innocent Catholic peers would be incinerated in the blast. On 26 October 1605, an anonymous warning letter (Source A) was delivered to Catholic Lord Monteagle, advising him to stay away because Parliament would receive "a terrible blow." Monteagle immediately handed the letter to the King's chief spymaster, Robert Cecil. At midnight on 4 November, royal guards raided the cellar, catching Guy Fawkes red-handed dressed in a cloak, boots, and spurs, carrying a dark lantern and slow-match fuses ready to ignite the powder.

[3.2] Fawkes was dragged before King James, coolly boasting that his intention was *"to blow you Scotch beggars back to your native mountains!"* James ordered him taken to the Tower of London to face the rack. Primary archival interrogation records (Source B) reveal the gruesome physical toll: on his first day, Fawkes boldly signed his alias "John Johnson" in a firm hand; after eight agonizing days having his joints dislocated on the rack, he scribbled a barely legible, broken signature "Guido", collapsing before he could finish his surname. Fawkes and his surviving co-conspirators were sentenced to be hanged, drawn, and quartered in January 1606.

[4.1] Historians have debated whether the Gunpowder Plot was an authentic grassroots Catholic rebellion or a conspiracy cleverly entrapped and exaggerated by spymaster Robert Cecil to consolidate royal power. While modern consensus agrees the plotters were entirely real, Cecil skillfully exploited the crisis to forge an invincible security state. In January 1606, Parliament passed the Thanksgiving Act, ordering every church in England to hold an annual sermon of deliverance on 5 November, establishing **Bonfire Night** as a permanent fixture of British national identity.

[4.2] The long-term consequences for British Catholics were catastrophic. Parliament imposed the **Oath of Allegiance (1606)**, requiring subjects to declare that the Pope had no authority to excommunicate or depose princes. Catholics were banned from practicing law, serving as army officers, voting, or attending university. The trauma of 1605 cemented a pervasive British national belief that Catholicism was equated with foreign tyranny and treason, an ideology that would violently explode again four decades later during the English Civil War.

Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L5: Who controlled Britain? The Ideological Battle

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand Charles I's Personal Rule (1629–1640) and the constitutional controversy of Ship Money.
- ☐ Analyze the dramatic climax of the Civil War: the trial and execution of Charles I on 30 January 1649.
- ☐ Evaluate the transition from Cromwell's Commonwealth to the 1689 Bill of Rights.

Source A : Contemporary Engraving of the Execution of King Charles I (1649)



German broadsheet engraving depicting the public beheading of King Charles I upon a black scaffold outside the Banqueting House in Whitehall on 30 January 1649.

Source B: The Great Seal of the Commonwealth of England (1651)



The official state seal designed by Thomas Simon for the English Republic, depicting the House of Commons in active debate instead of a monarch.

[1.1] In 1625, King **Charles I** succeeded his father James. Rigid, aloof, and intensely insecure, Charles held an uncompromising belief in the **Divine Right of Kings**: he genuinely believed that the monarch was accountable only to God, and that questioning royal policy was equivalent to blasphemy. When MPs in

the House of Commons refused to grant him taxation without redressing grievances, Charles dissolved Parliament in 1629 and embarked on eleven years of personal governance known as the **"Eleven Years' Tyranny"** (Personal Rule).

[1.2] To fund his royal court without summoning Parliament, Charles resurrected ancient, obsolete feudal levies. His most controversial tactic was levying **Ship Money**: traditionally a medieval tax paid exclusively by coastal towns during wartime to construct warships, Charles illegally extended the tax to inland counties in peacetime! When Buckinghamshire landowner John Hampden refused to pay twenty shillings on principle in 1637, he was prosecuted by royal judges. Millions of Englishmen concluded that Charles was seeking to strip away their historic liberties and establish a French-style absolute Catholic tyranny.

[2.1] War became unavoidable in January 1642 when Charles stormed into the House of Commons with 400 armed guards to arrest five leading MPs for treason—only to find that "the birds had flown." In August 1642, Charles raised his royal standard at Nottingham, plunging England into seven years of horrific Civil War. The nation fractured: **Cavaliers** (Royalists supporting the Crown and Church of England) fought **Roundheads** (Parliamentarians and Puritans fighting for liberty and parliamentary supremacy). Over 200,000 Englishmen died from combat and disease—a higher proportion of the population than Britain lost in World War I.

[2.2] Parliament triumphed through military innovation: **Oliver Cromwell** created the **New Model Army**, a professional, disciplined force of godly soldiers promoted on merit rather than aristocratic birth. The New Model Army crushed the Royalists at Naseby (1645). When Charles secretly plotted with Scottish invaders to start a second civil war, Cromwell and hardline army officers decided that peace was impossible while the King lived. In December 1648, Colonel Pride barred moderate MPs from Parliament ("Pride's Purge"), leaving a radical "Rump Parliament" that created a High Court of Justice to put Charles I on trial for high treason against his own people.

Source A : Contemporary Engraving of the Execution of King Charles I (1649)



German broadsheet engraving depicting the public beheading of King Charles I upon a black scaffold outside the Banqueting House in Whitehall on 30 January 1649.

[3.1] At his trial in Westminster Hall, Charles refused to remove his hat or enter a plea, haughtily demanding: *"By what lawful authority am I brought hither? No earthly power can justly call me, who am your King, to account."* But the court declared him a *"tyrant, traitor, murderer, and public enemy."* On 30 January 1649, Charles was marched onto a scaffold outside the Banqueting House at Whitehall (Source A). Showing dignified courage, Charles requested two shirts because the morning was freezing: *"The season is so sharp as probably may make me shake, which some observers will imagine proceeds from fear. I would have no such imputation!"* The masked executioner severed his head with one clean blow.

[3.2] For the next eleven years, England was a republic: the **Commonwealth**. As captured in the Great

Seal of 1651 (Source B), royal symbols were systematically obliterated: the seal depicted the House of Commons in session rather than a monarch on horseback. But liberty proved elusive. Cromwell dismissed Parliament by military force in 1653, declaring himself **Lord Protector**—ruling as a military dictator, dividing England into eleven military districts governed by puritan Major-Generals who banned Christmas, horse racing, and theatre.

[4.1] Exhausted by Puritan military rule, England restored Charles II to the throne in the **Restoration of 1660**. Yet the constitutional question remained unresolved until 1688. When Charles II's Catholic brother, **James II**, attempted to suspend laws and rule without Parliament, MPs invited Dutch Prince **William of Orange** and his wife Mary (James's Protestant daughter) to invade England in the **Glorious Revolution of 1688**. James II fled into exile without a fight.

[4.2] In 1689, William and Mary accepted the historic **Bill of Rights**. The statute permanently transformed Britain into a **constitutional monarchy**: the monarch could never suspend laws, levy taxes without Parliament, or maintain a standing army in peacetime. Freedom of speech in parliamentary debate was guaranteed forever. The bloody ideological struggle that began with Charles I's divine pretensions in 1629 ended with the supreme authority of Parliament firmly etched into British law.

Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L6: Who controlled Britain? The Economic Shift

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

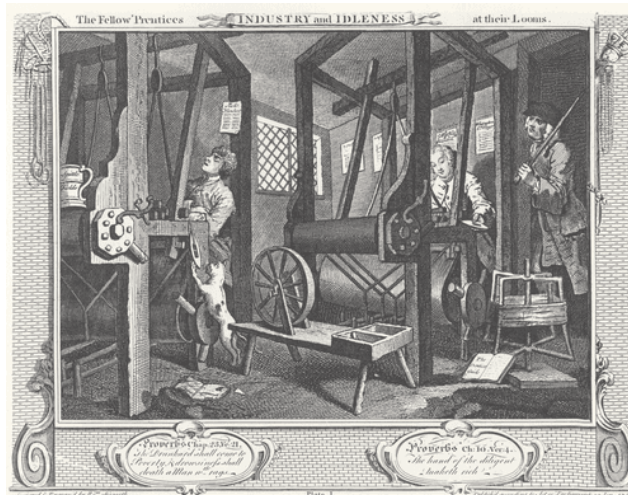
- ☐ Understand how the Navigation Acts (1651) enforced a mercantilist monopoly on colonial trade.
- ☐ Analyze the Financial Revolution: the Bank of England (1694) and London coffee houses.
- ☐ Evaluate the rise of the "fiscal-military state" and the changing balance of British social power.

Source A : The Courtyard of the Royal Exchange, London (c. 1670)



Contemporary engraving showing merchants from Turkey, Holland, the West Indies, and Venice conducting international transactions in the pillared quadrangle of the Royal Exchange.

Source B : William Hogarth's "Industry and Idleness" (1747)



Engraving contrasting the industrious apprentice Francis Goodchild, who works hard and becomes Lord Mayor of London, with the idle apprentice Tom Idle, who ends on the gallows.

[1.1] Throughout the Middle Ages, power in Britain resided in the soil. Wealthy dukes, earls, and barons controlled vast agricultural estates worked by tenant farmers; money was physical gold and silver, and commerce was regarded by gentlemen as vulgar and beneath their dignity. But following the English Civil

War, this ancient feudal social order was overtaken by an unstoppable economic revolution. Landowners embraced **agrarian capitalism**: enclosing common lands with hedges, draining fens, and introducing selective livestock breeding. Agriculture was no longer about basic family subsistence; it was an aggressive, market-driven commercial enterprise producing grain and wool for profit.

[1.2] To guarantee that British merchants dominated the oceans, Oliver Cromwell's Commonwealth passed the revolutionary **Navigation Act of 1651**. This was the cornerstone of **mercantilism**—the economic theory that global wealth was limited, and that a nation must export more than it imported while hoarding bullion. The Act decreed that goods imported from Asia, Africa, or America into Britain or its colonies could be carried only on English-built ships crewed by at least seventy-five percent English sailors. This policy dealt a crushing blow to Dutch trade competitors and transformed the Royal Navy into a permanent global shield for British merchant shipping.

[2.1] Between 1688 and 1720, Britain experienced a **Financial Revolution** that laid the groundwork for modern capitalism. In 1694, when King William III needed millions of pounds to wage war against the superpower of France, Scottish merchant William Paterson devised a brilliant solution: the creation of the **Bank of England**. Rather than kings begging private moneylenders for extortionate short-term loans, a chartered corporation of wealthy merchants loaned £1.2 million directly to the government at a modest eight percent interest. In return, the Bank was granted the right to issue banknotes and manage the **National Debt**. This guaranteed that Britain could borrow enormous sums of money cheaply and reliably, funding a colossal navy that rival nations could never match.

[2.2] Meanwhile, the daily deal-making of capitalism unfolded not in royal palaces, but in the smoky, caffeine-fueled atmosphere of **London coffee houses**. Introductions like coffee and tea were new and fashionable; for the admission fee of one penny, merchants, sea captains, and investors packed into coffee houses like Garraway's, Jonathan's, and Edward Lloyd's. Nicknamed "**Penny Universities**", these bustling spaces democratized information: sea captains traded shipping intelligence, merchants formed joint-stock companies, Jonathan's Coffee House evolved into the London Stock Exchange, and Lloyd's Coffee House transformed into the world's greatest maritime insurance market.

Source A : The Courtyard of the Royal Exchange, London (c. 1670)



Contemporary engraving showing merchants from Turkey, Holland, the West Indies, and Venice conducting international transactions in the pillared quadrangle of the Royal Exchange.

[3.1] Archival records reveal how global commerce remade London's physical and social geography. In the vast pillared quadrangle of the rebuilt **Royal Exchange** (Source A), the world was literally divided into commercial zones: beneath stone arches, London brokers in woollen coats haggled with merchants in Ottoman turbans, Dutch trading agents, and Caribbean plantation factors. Here, fortunes were made and lost on the fluctuating prices of Virginia tobacco, Jamaican sugar, and Bengal calico. A new social class—the **bourgeoisie** (commercial middle class)—rose to challenge the ancient supremacy of the landed

aristocracy.

[3.2] This cultural triumph of merchant values was captured with biting moral clarity by artist William Hogarth in his 1747 engraving series *Industry and Idleness* (Source B). In the prints, nobility of blood is made completely irrelevant: the industrious merchant apprentice Francis Goodchild works diligently at his loom, marries his master's daughter, accumulates wealth, and rises to become Lord Mayor of London; meanwhile, the idle apprentice who wastes time gambling ends his life on the gallows at Tyburn. The message to eighteenth-century Britons was undeniable: wealth and power now belonged to those who commanded commercial capital.

[4.1] In his groundbreaking study *The Sinews of Power* (1989), historian John Brewer demonstrated that Britain's rise to global superpower status was not due to superior military tactics, but to its revolutionary financial architecture: the **fiscal-military state**. By combining efficient excise taxation with the credible public credit of the Bank of England, Britain was able to spend astronomical sums on warships and global garrisons without collapsing into the bankruptcy that repeatedly crippled France and Spain.

[4.2] However, this economic miracle had a deeply exploitative foundation. The booming trade at the Royal Exchange and the soaring dividends of London investors were powered directly by imperial commodities: sugar, tobacco, and rum. These lucrative goods were produced not by free English laborers, but by millions of enslaved Africans trapped in the brutal, murderous machinery of transatlantic slavery.

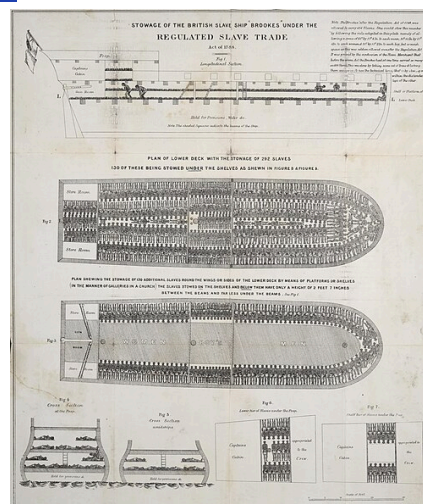
Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L7: What were the mechanics of the Transatlantic Slave Trade?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

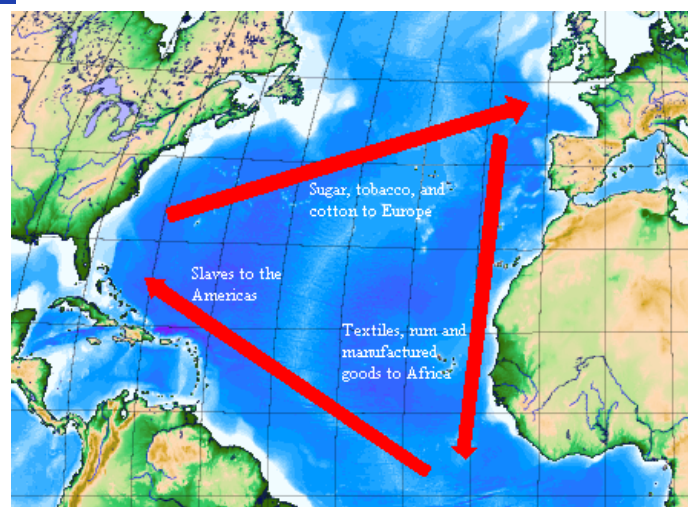
- ☐ Understand the mechanics and geometry of the Triangular Trade across three continents.
- ☐ Interrogate the forensic geometry of the slave ship *Brookes* (1788).
- ☐ Evaluate Eric Williams' thesis regarding the link between slavery profits and British industrialization.

Source A : Diagram of the Slave Ship *Brookes* (1788)



*Forensic architectural cross-section of the Liverpool slave ship *Brookes*, published by the Abolition Society, illustrating 454 enslaved Africans packed into its lower decks.*

Source B : Schematic Map of the Transatlantic Triangular Trade Network



Cartographic diagram illustrating the prevailing Atlantic wind currents and the three commercial legs connecting Britain, West Africa, and the Caribbean plantations.

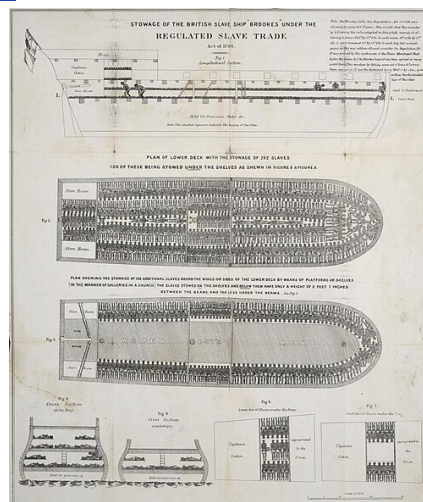
[1.1] In the late seventeenth century, British consumer culture was radically transformed by imported imperial luxuries: tea, coffee, chocolate, and above all, **sugar**. Sugar was no longer a rare medicine for royalty; it became a staple food for the working class, sweetening bitter tea to provide quick calories for long factory shifts. But sugarcane was an exceptionally grueling, lethal crop: canes had to be planted, harvested with machetes in tropical heat, crushed in heavy iron mills, and boiled in toxic, bubbling copper vats. When indigenous populations were annihilated by Eurasian disease and European indentured servants proved unable to survive the brutal labor regime, plantation owners turned to the forced labor of enslaved Africans.

[1.2] In 1672, King Charles II granted a royal charter creating the **Royal African Company**, headed by his brother James, Duke of York. The company was granted a state monopoly to capture and transport enslaved human beings from West Africa to English colonies in Jamaica, Barbados, and Virginia. The Duke of York personally ordered company captives branded on the chest with the letters "DoY" or "RAC" using red-hot irons, cementing the horrific reality of chattel slavery: human beings were legally transformed into commercial commodities to be bought, insured, and worked to death for British profit.

[2.1] By the eighteenth century, British merchants had perfected the **Triangular Trade** (Source B)—a self-reinforcing oceanic machinery operating across three continents. On the **First Leg (Outward Passage)**, ships sailed from Bristol and Liverpool laden with British manufactured goods: flintlock muskets from Birmingham, iron bars, brass pans, gun flints, and Manchester cotton textiles. Arriving at fortified West African slave forts like Cape Coast Castle and Elmina, captains traded these goods to local African monarchs and warlords in exchange for war captives and kidnapped families.

[2.2] The **Second Leg (The Middle Passage)** was the most concentrated theatre of human terror in history. Stripped naked and shaved, enslaved men were chained together in pairs by their ankles and wrists and crammed into sweltering, lightless decks beneath the waterline. Captains practiced "tight packing": stacking human bodies side-by-side on tiered wooden shelves with barely eighteen inches of vertical headroom. Chained in pools of blood, vomit, and human excrement, captives endured six to twelve weeks of horrific torment. Dysentery (the "bloody flux"), smallpox, and ophthalmia raged through the hold; those who went insane were flogged, and those who attempted suicide by starvation were force-fed using the *speculum oris*, a horrific iron screw device that prized open jaws. Between ten and fifteen percent of all captives died before reaching America, their bodies thrown overboard to following sharks.

Source A : Diagram of the Slave Ship Brookes (1788)



Forensic architectural cross-section of the Liverpool slave ship Brookes, published by the Abolition Society, illustrating 454 enslaved Africans packed into its lower decks.

[3.1] The cold, calculated cruelty of the trade is permanently captured in the famous architectural diagram of the slave ship **Brookes** (Source A). Published in 1788 by abolitionist campaigner Thomas Clarkson, this clinical technical drawing shocked the public conscience: it depicted 454 human beings stowed in precise rows like logs of timber or barrels of rum, allocating a space six feet long by sixteen inches wide for an adult male—literally less room than a corpse inside a wooden coffin. On earlier voyages, the captain admitted to packing over 600 captives into the same hull, proving that human life was treated entirely as disposable cargo.

[3.2] Surviving captives who survived the Middle Passage were auctioned like livestock in Kingston, Bridgetown, or Charleston. On the **Third Leg (Home Passage)**, slave ships returned to Britain packed with the raw fruits of unfree labor: hogsheads of raw brown muscovado sugar, barrels of Jamaican rum, crates of Virginian tobacco, and bales of Carolina cotton. The profits flowed directly into British port cities: Liverpool grew from a fishing village of 5,000 in 1700 into Europe's premier slave-trading port by 1795, launching over 100 slave ships annually and controlling eighty percent of Britain's slave trade.

[4.1] In 1944, Trinidadian historian **Eric Williams** published a groundbreaking masterpiece: *Capitalism and Slavery*. Williams shattered comfortable Victorian narratives that portrayed Britain merely as a noble, compassionate nation that abolished slavery in 1833. Instead, Williams advanced the radical thesis that **the profits of transatlantic slavery financed the Industrial Revolution**. Fortunes amassed in the slave trade built Liverpool's docks, capitalized private merchant banks like Barclays and Barings, financed the construction of canals and railways, and funded James Watt's revolutionary steam engine experiments.

[4.2] Today, British history directly confronts this legacy. The grand neoclassical buildings of Bristol and Liverpool, the stately country houses of the English aristocracy, and the booming cotton mills of Lancashire were all fertilized by the blood, sweat, and agony of enslaved Africans. Yet enslaved people were never passive victims in this machine; across the ocean, they fought back with ferocious courage.

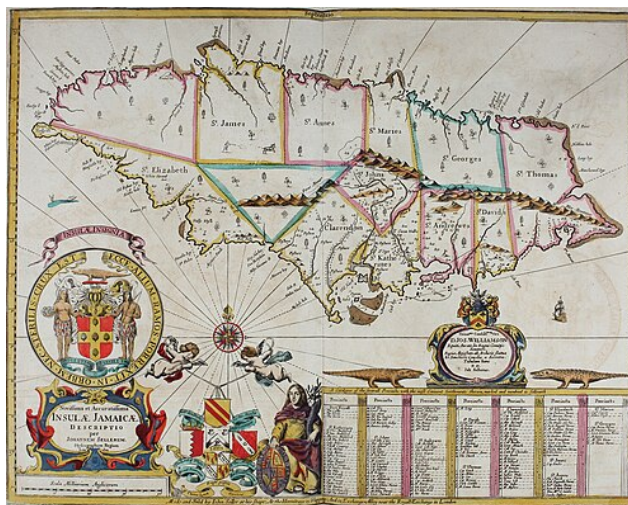
Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L8: How did enslaved Africans resist the Transatlantic Slave Trade?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the broad spectrum of resistance: from subtle daily subversion to violent insurrection.
- ☐ Analyze the military victory of the Jamaican Maroons led by Queen Nanny.
- ☐ Evaluate the impact of Olaudah Equiano and Black abolitionists in dismantling the trade.

Source A : Contemporary Print of the Jamaican Maroons in the Blue Mountains (1739)



Engraving depicting armed Jamaican Maroon warriors negotiating the 1739 Peace Treaty with British colonial officers in the rugged Blue Mountains.

Source B : Frontispiece Portrait of Olaudah Equiano from his 1789 Autobiography



Engraved portrait of Olaudah Equiano (Gustavus Vassa) holding an open Bible, published as the frontispiece to his bestselling 1789 autobiography.

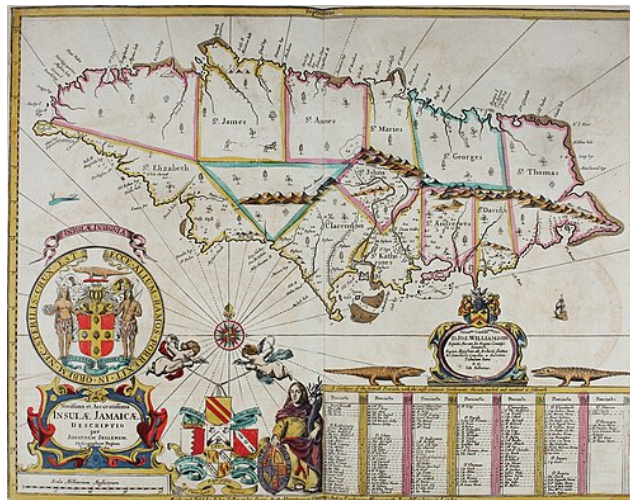
[1.1] For centuries, Victorian histories depicted enslaved Africans as silent, passive victims who waited patiently for noble white parliamentarians like William Wilberforce to set them free. Modern scholarship has obliterated this myth. In truth, African resistance began the very second captives were ambushed in their homelands and continued relentlessly at every stage of their enslavement. Captives rebelled in coastal barracoons, leapt overboard into shark-infested waters to drown as free people rather than submit to chains, and launched armed mutinies aboard slave ships.

[1.2] Shipboard insurrections were remarkably frequent: maritime records prove that violent revolts broke out on **at least ten percent of all slave voyages** across the Atlantic. Captives smuggled barrel hoops to pick locks, attacked crews with broken shackles, and in famous cases like the *Clara* (1729) or the *Amistad* (1839), overpowered the white crew and seized control of the ship. Knowing that mutinies could erupt at any moment, British captains invested in heavily armed crew barricades with swivel cannons aimed directly at the slave deck, terrified of their own human cargo.

[2.1] Once sold onto American and Caribbean plantations, enslaved people engaged in a continuous **spectrum of resistance**. Subtle daily resistance was universal: laborers worked slowly, feigned illness, deliberately broke expensive sugarcane machetes, sabotaged sugar boiling houses, and preserved banned African languages, drumming, and religious traditions like Obeah. Women used herbal knowledge to administer secret abortifacients rather than bear children into lifelong chattel bondage. On a more dangerous level, enslaved rebels plotted armed uprisings, such as the **Stono Rebellion** in South Carolina (1739), where eighty enslaved men marched toward Spanish Florida beating drums and shouting for liberty.

[2.2] The most formidable armed resistance emerged in Jamaica among the **Maroons**—communities of self-liberated Africans who fled into the impenetrable limestone ravines of the Cockpit Country and the misty heights of the Blue Mountains. Led by a brilliant military and spiritual leader named **Queen Nanny**, the Windward Maroons waged a savage guerrilla war against the British military throughout the 1730s. Disguising themselves with leafy branches, ambushing redcoats from mountain ledges, and communicating across valleys using a cow horn called the *abeng*, Nanny's warriors slaughtered British regiments sent to re-enslave them.

Source A : Contemporary Print of the Jamaican Maroons in the Blue Mountains (1739)



as Jamaica's only female National Hero.

[3.2] In Britain, the weapon of resistance was the pen. In 1789, **Olaudah Equiano**—a former enslaved Igbo man who had survived the Middle Passage and bought his freedom—published his bestselling autobiography: *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* (Source B). Depicted on the frontispiece dressed in fine Georgian attire holding a Bible, Equiano delivered a devastating blow to pro-slavery propagandists who claimed Africans were subhuman. Equiano joined the **Sons of Africa**, a political group of free Black Londoners that included Ottobah Cugoana, traveling across Britain giving fiery public lectures and personally lobbying Parliament.

[4.1] Historians remain engaged in a profound debate over what truly destroyed the Transatlantic Slave Trade in 1807. Traditional imperial historians credited white parliamentary reformers like William Wilberforce and Thomas Clarkson, celebrating British abolition as a triumph of Christian morality. Conversely, revisionist historians, beginning with Eric Williams and advanced by scholars like Professor Hilary Beckles, argue that the trade collapsed because enslaved rebellions made the Caribbean impossible to control. Constant slave uprisings made plantation insurance costs skyrocket and required thousands of British troops to suppress, rendering unfree labor an economic liability.

[4.2] What is indisputable is that without the courageous resistance of enslaved Africans—from the fierce guerrilla warfare of Queen Nanny to the eloquent literature of Olaudah Equiano—the abolition of the slave trade would never have occurred. Their courage proved that human dignity could never be extinguished by chains, whips, or commercial ledgers.

Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

L9: How 'modern' was Britain by 1750? (Synthesis & Assessment)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

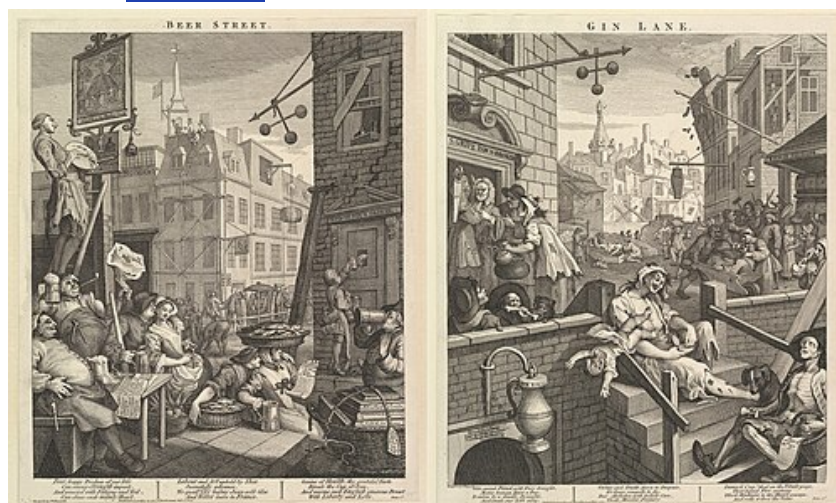
- ☐ Trace the long-term arc from peripheral 1450 to global 1750.
- ☐ Interrogate imperial propaganda versus urban social reality using Source A and Source B.
- ☐ Evaluate the disciplinary concept of "modernity" in historical debate.

Source A : The East Offering its Riches to Britannia (1778) by Spiridione Roma



Magnificent ceiling painting commissioned by the East India Company for its headquarters in Leadenhall Street, London, depicting India and China kneeling to present pearls and porcelain to Britannia.

Source B : Gin Lane (1751) by William Hogarth



Engraving depicting the social collapse, starvation, and despair caused by unregulated gin drinking in the squalid London slum of St Giles.

[1.1] In 1450, England was an insular, impoverished medieval kingdom on the fringes of Europe: recovering from the Black Death, torn apart by feudal baronies, with an unpaved capital of 50,000 citizens and zero overseas colonies. By 1750, three centuries later, Britain had undergone the most astonishing metamorphosis in human history. London was now a sprawling imperial metropolis of nearly 700,000 citizens—the financial, commercial, and maritime capital of the Western world. British merchant ships dominated every major oceanic trade route, the Royal Navy was the undisputed master of the seas, and British rule spanned from the sugar islands of the Caribbean to the trading factories of Bengal.

[1.2] Domestically, Britain appeared to be the beacon of political stability and intellectual enlightenment. While absolute monarchs in France, Spain, and Russia ruled without parliaments, Britain was a constitutional monarchy governed by the rule of law, protected by the 1689 Bill of Rights. The Scientific Revolution and the Scottish Enlightenment had replaced medieval superstition with Newtonian physics and empirical science. Wealthy Britons enjoyed a "consumer revolution": drinking Jamaican sugar and Chinese tea from porcelain cups in elegant Georgian salons furnished with mahogany tables, discussing literature and global politics in comfortable townhouses.

[2.1] Yet beneath this glittering veneer of Georgian enlightenment lay a dark, deeply divided society. Britain's dazzling commercial wealth was concentrated in the hands of a tiny oligarchy of landed aristocrats, London bankers, and Caribbean plantation owners. For the vast majority of ordinary working people, life was a desperate, unceasing struggle for survival. Enclosure acts had driven hundreds of thousands of landless agricultural laborers off common village greens and into squalid urban slums like St Giles and Whitechapel, where whole families were packed into damp, airless cellar dwellings without running water, sewers, or sanitation.

[2.2] The psychological despair of the urban poor exploded in the catastrophic "**Gin Craze**" of the 1730s and 1740s. Unregulated corn spirits—cheap, potent, and often adulterated with sulfuric acid and turpentine—flooded the capital: Londoners consumed over eleven million gallons of gin a year. In squalid alleyways, "dram shops" advertised that customers could get "*Drunk for a penny, dead drunk for twopence, with straw for nothing!*" Infant mortality soared: in the poorest London parishes, three out of four children died before their fifth birthday, their bodies unceremoniously dumped in lime pits.

Source A : The East Offering its Riches to Britannia (1778) by Spiridione Roma



Magnificent ceiling painting commissioned by the East India Company for its headquarters in Leadenhall Street, London, depicting India and China kneeling to present pearls and porcelain to Britannia.

[3.1] The striking contradiction of 1750 Britain is captured when comparing two famous primary artworks. In Spiridione Roma's grandiose ceiling painting for the East India Company, *The East Offering its Riches to Britannia* (Source A), Britain is depicted as a serene classical goddess receiving the voluntary homage of the world: female personifications of India and China kneel humbly before her, pouring out baskets of pearls, jewels, and tea chests. It was the ultimate corporate propaganda: an image of benign, peaceful

commerce that erased the brutal realities of naval cannon, military coercion, and colonial famine.

[3.2] The brutal reality of domestic Britain is captured in William Hogarth's searing 1751 masterpiece *Gin Lane* (Source B). Set in the notorious St Giles slum, Hogarth depicts an apocalyptic scene of social disintegration: in the foreground, an intoxicated mother drops her baby from a staircase to its death, while a skeletal ballad singer starves and an impoverished soldier pawns his sword for one more dram of liquor. Far from an enlightened modern paradise, 1750 Britain was a society of grotesque extremes: colossal imperial fortunes built alongside desperate domestic destitution and human degradation.

[4.1] Historians remain divided over whether 1750 Britain should be celebrated as the world's first "modern" society. Liberal constitutional historians emphasize the positive transformation: Britain was the pioneer of parliamentary democracy, the rule of law, religious toleration, and capitalist innovation, providing the political and financial stability that would soon launch the Industrial Revolution.

[4.2] Conversely, social and post-colonial historians argue that Britain's "modernity" was an illusion enjoyed only by a wealthy elite. They emphasize that the British Empire was built on the enslavement of over three million Africans, the violent dispossession of indigenous nations in America, and the commercial plunder of India, while its own working class perished in squalor. The year 1750 was not the end of Britain's transformation, but the launchpad for a new industrial world that would export British power, industry, and empire to every corner of the earth.

Q1. Master Disciplinary Enquiry Task

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